

Individual Report for POLI_SCI_210-0_20: Intro to Empirical Methods (Gustavo Diaz)

Project Title: **Course and Teacher Evaluations CTEC Spring 2026**

Courses Audience: **62**

Responses Received: **48**

Response Ratio: **77.4%**

Report Comments

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Creation Date: **Sunday, June 28, 2026**

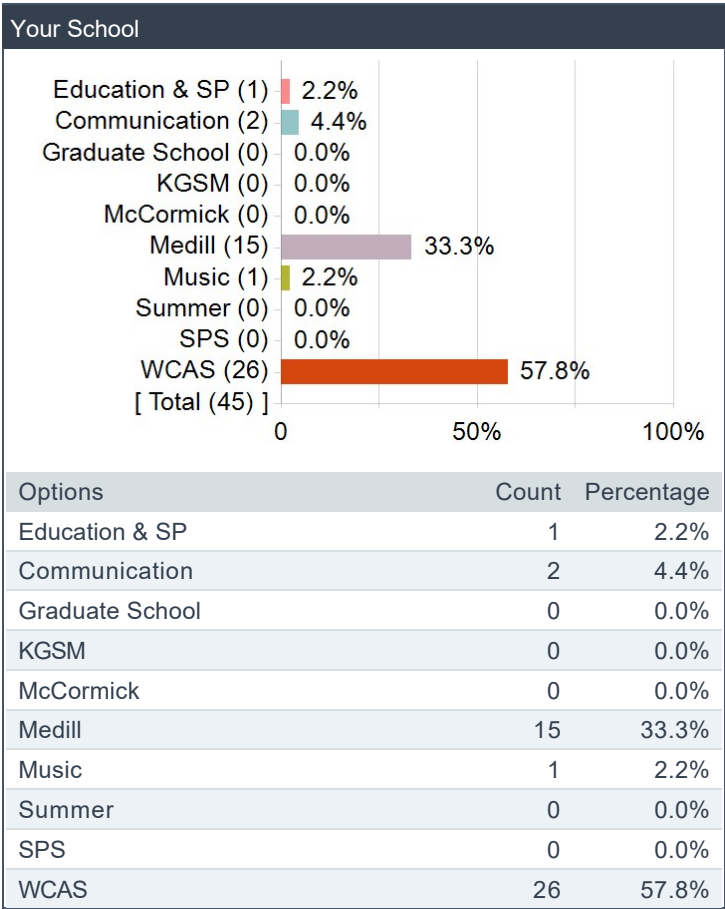
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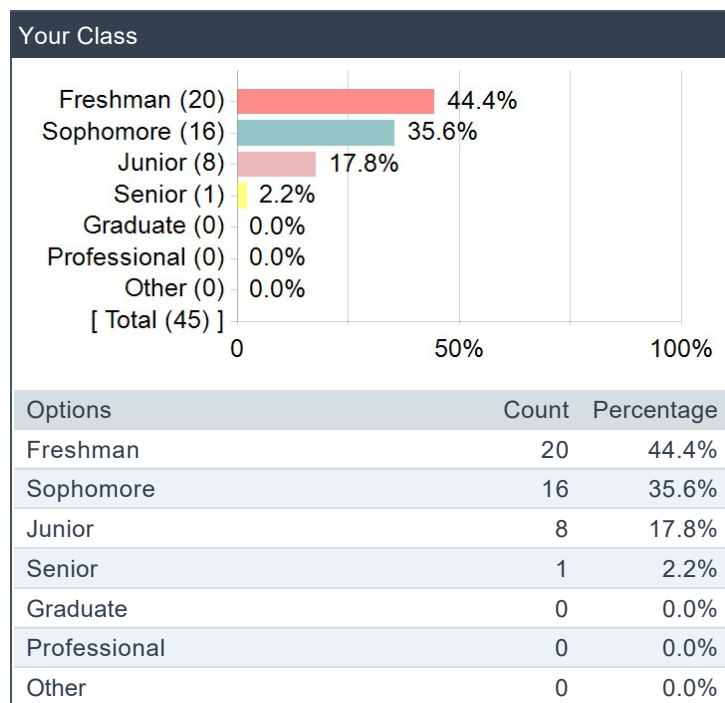
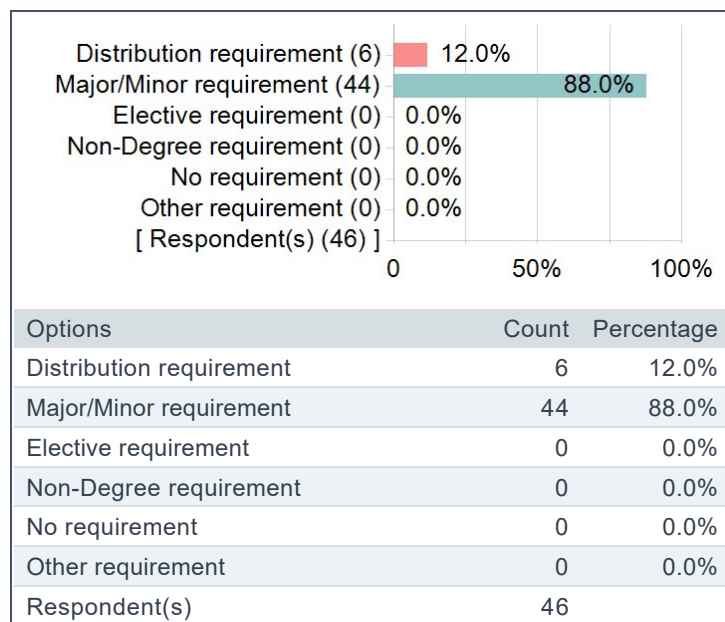
Course Evaluations

Instructor	Course
Gustavo Diaz	POLI_SCI_210-0_20: Intro to Empirical Methods

DEMOGRAPHICS

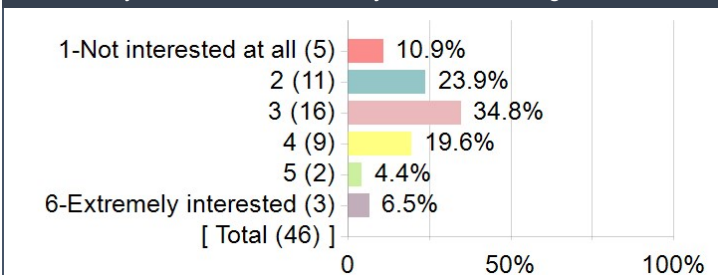
Your School



Your Class**What is your reason for taking the course? (mark all that apply)**

What was your Interest in this subject before taking the course?

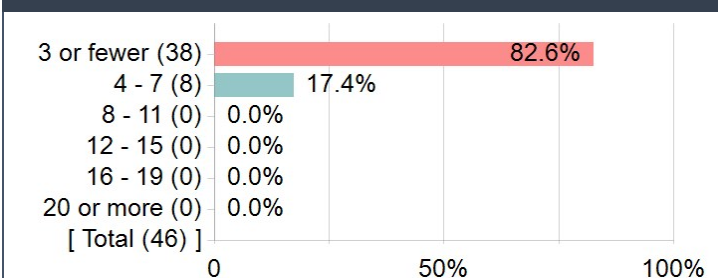
What was your interest in this subject before taking the course?



Options	Count	Percentage
1-Not interested at all	5	10.9%
2	11	23.9%
3	16	34.8%
4	9	19.6%
5	2	4.3%
6-Extremely interested	3	6.5%

TIME-SURVEY QUESTION**Estimate the average number of hours per week you spent on this course outside of class and lab time.**

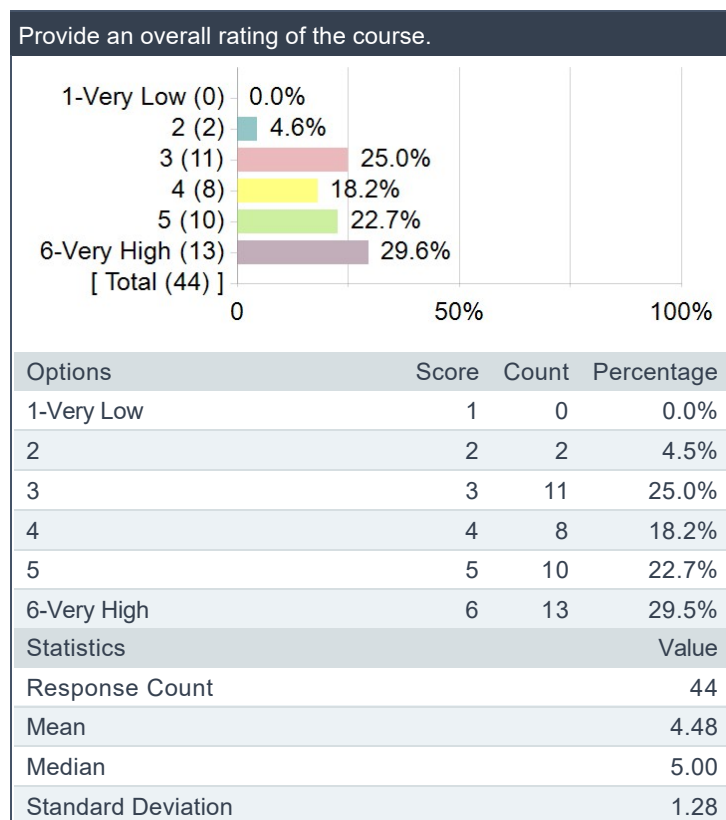
Estimate the average number of hours per week you spent on this course outside of class and lab time.



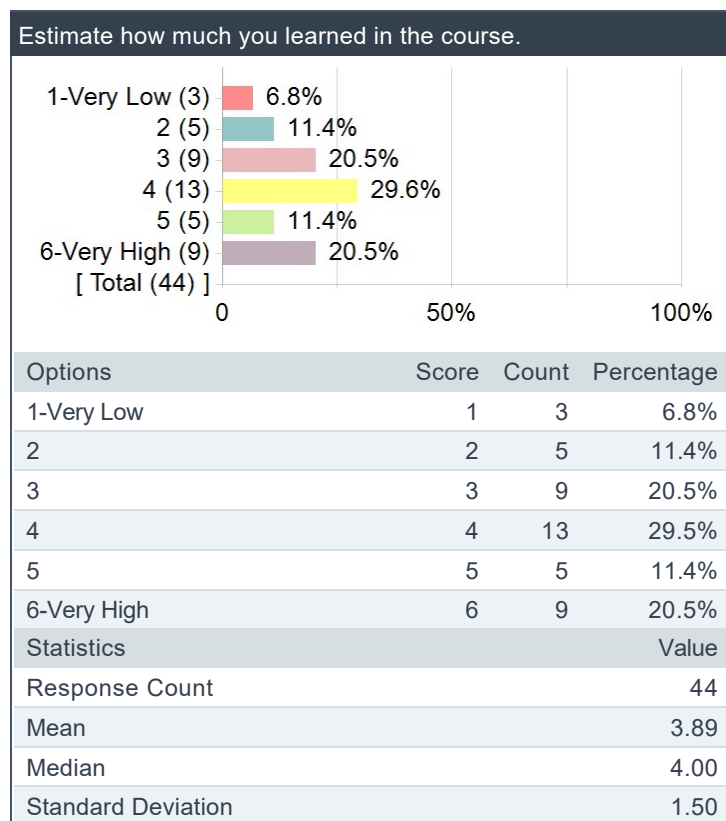
Options	Count	Percentage
3 or fewer	38	82.6%
4 - 7	8	17.4%
8 - 11	0	0.0%
12 - 15	0	0.0%
16 - 19	0	0.0%
20 or more	0	0.0%

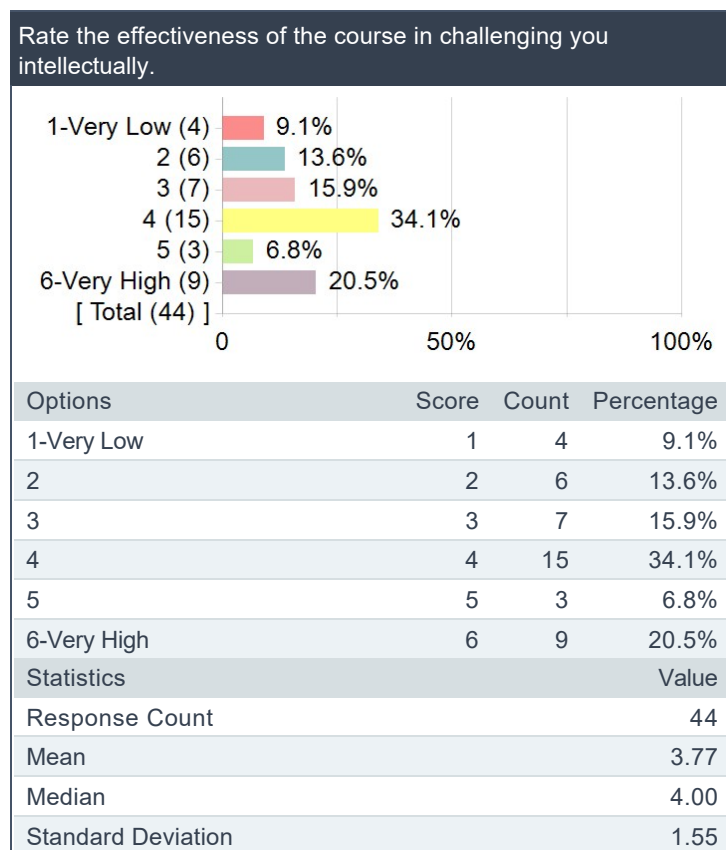
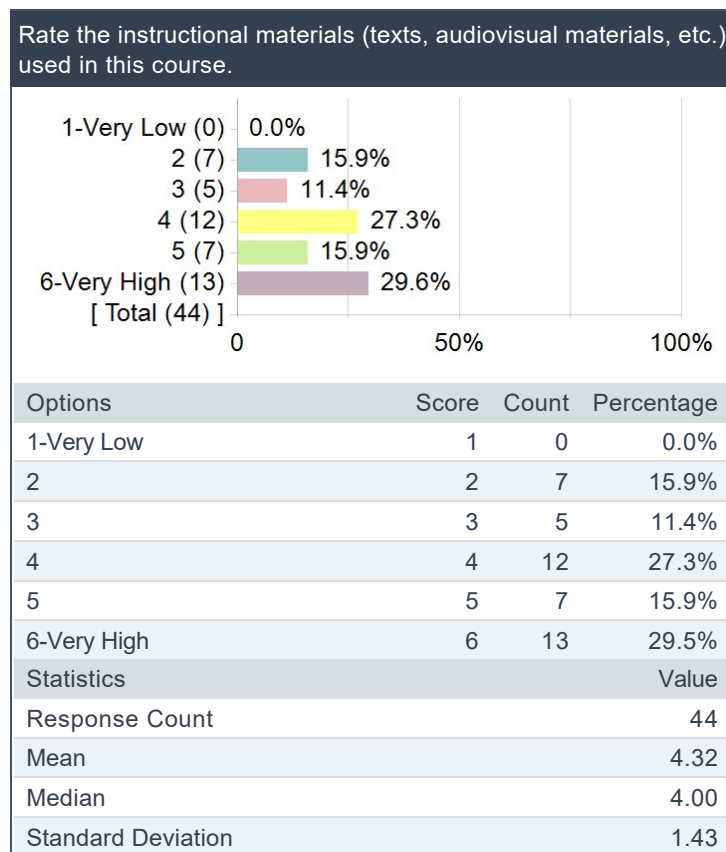
COURSE QUESTIONS

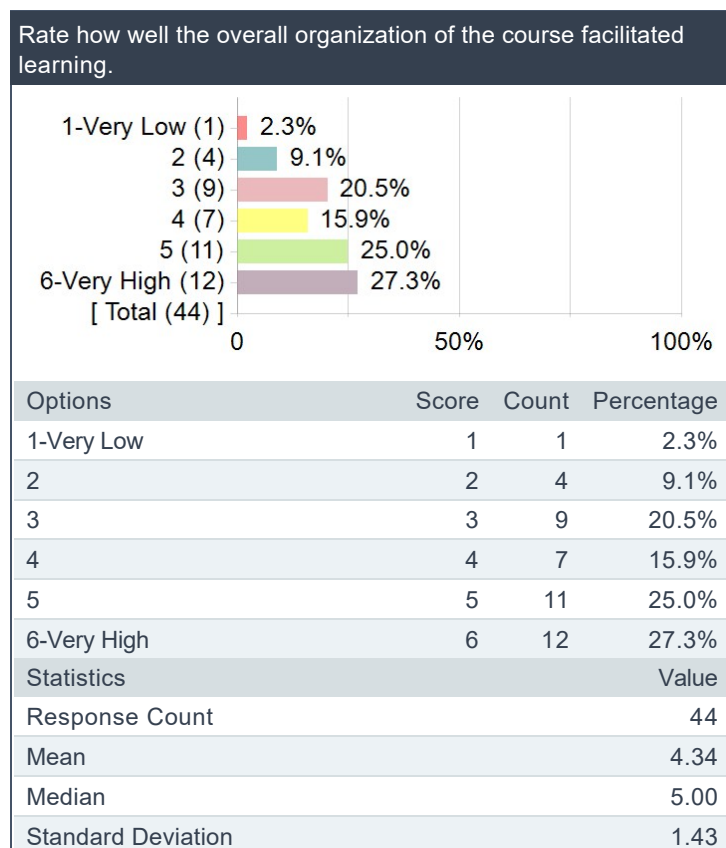
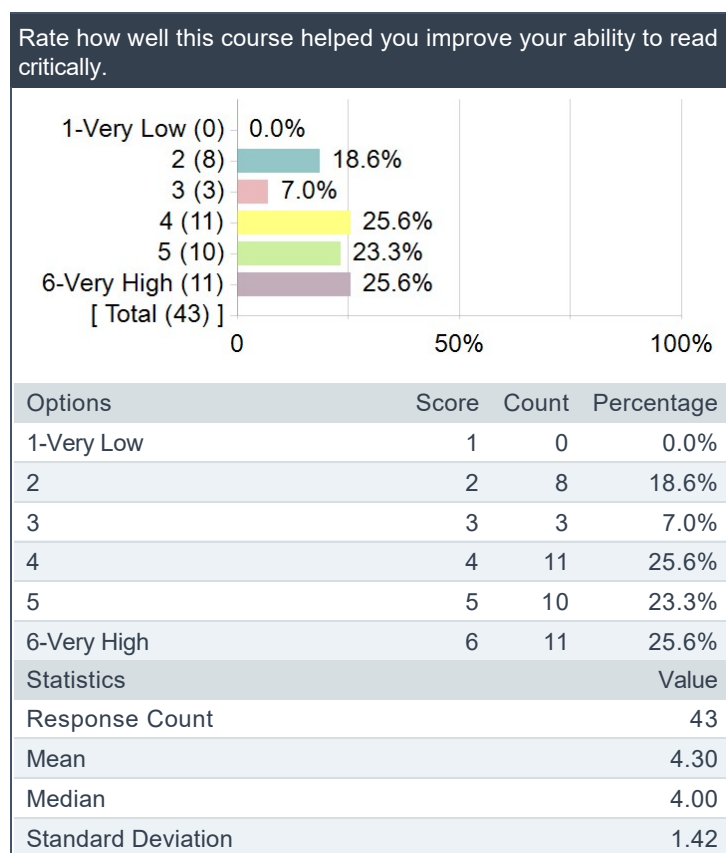
Provide an overall rating of the course.



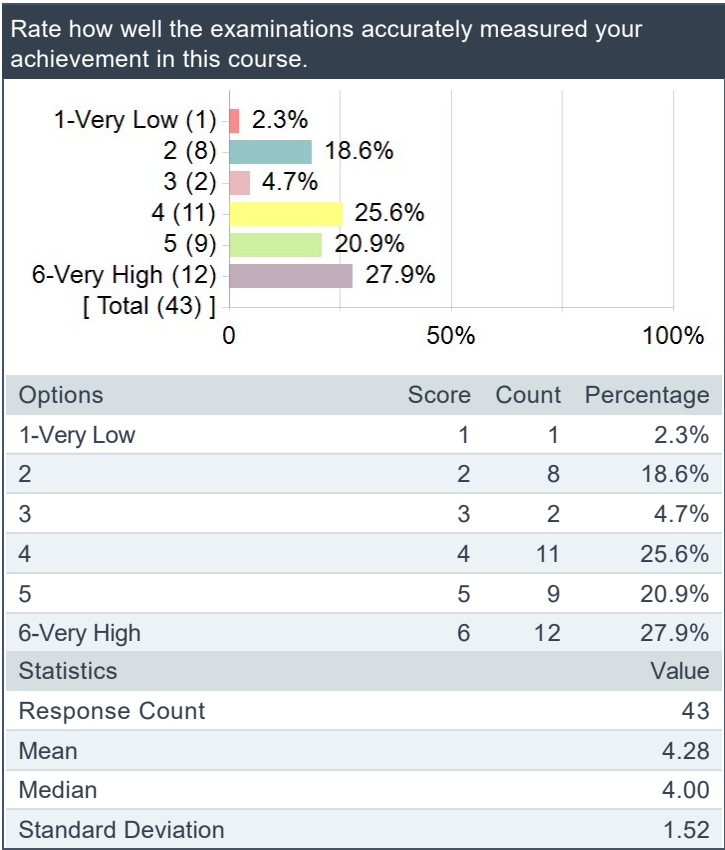
Estimate how much you learned in the course.



Rate the effectiveness of the course in challenging you intellectually.**Rate the instructional materials (texts, audiovisual materials, etc.) used in this course.**

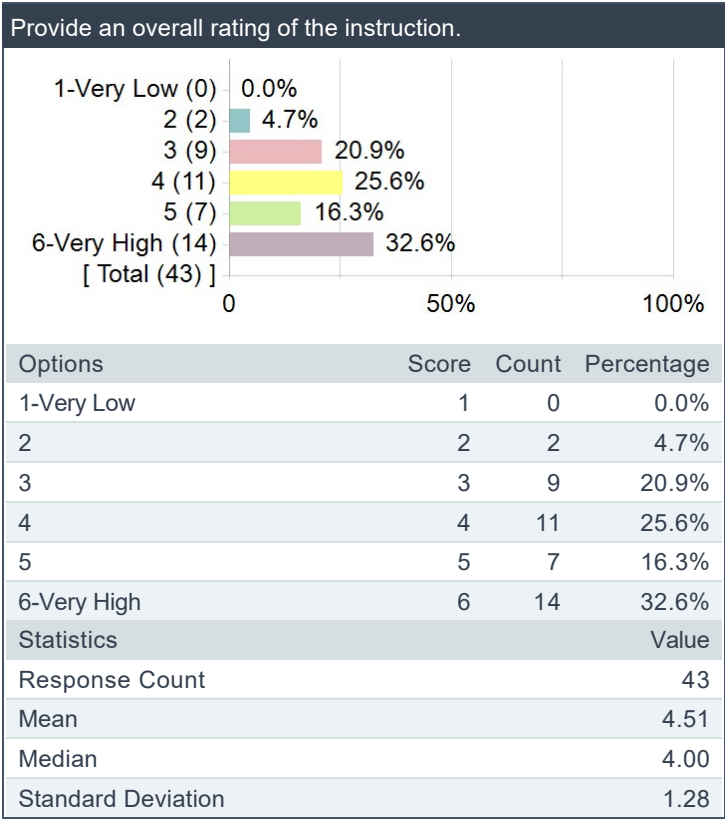
Rate how well the overall organization of the course facilitated learning.**Rate how well this course helped you improve your ability to read critically.**

Rate how well the examinations accurately measured your achievement in this course.



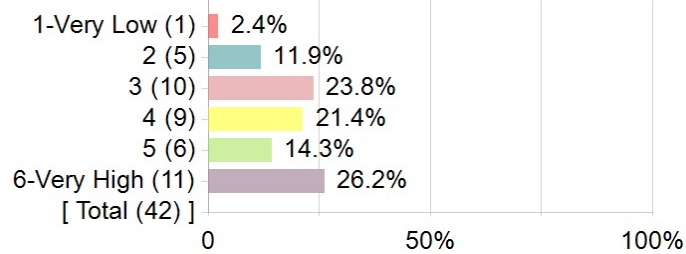
INSTRUCTOR QUESTIONS

Provide an overall rating of the instruction.



Rate the effectiveness of the instructor in stimulating your interest in the subject.

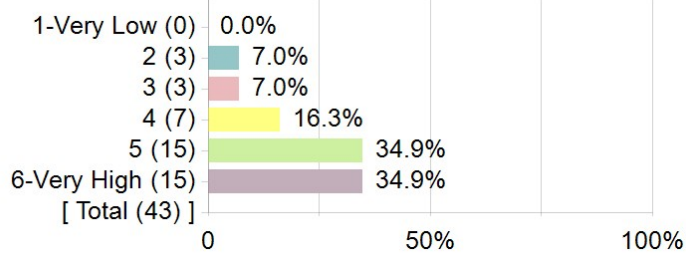
Rate the effectiveness of the instructor in stimulating your interest in the subject.



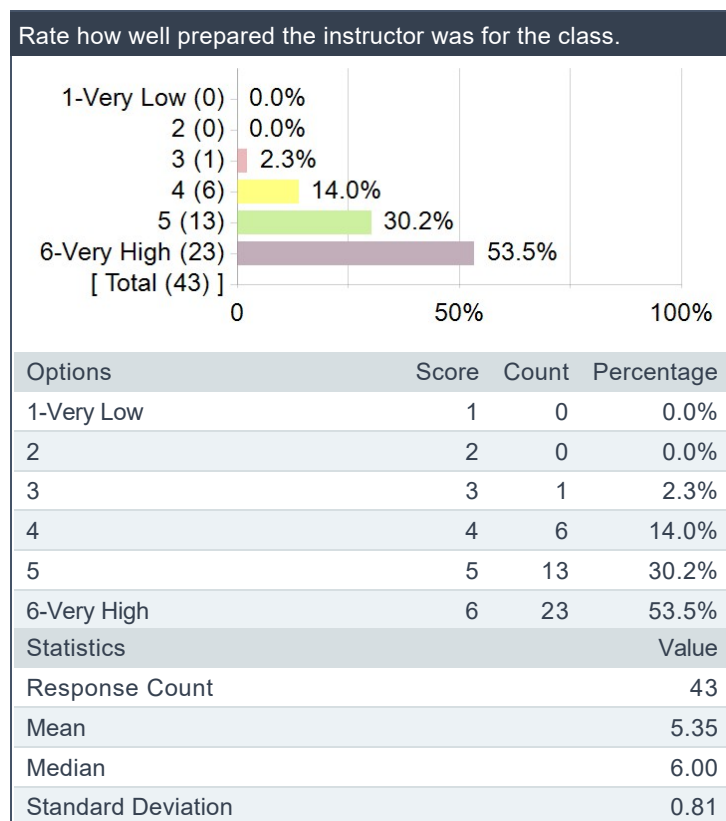
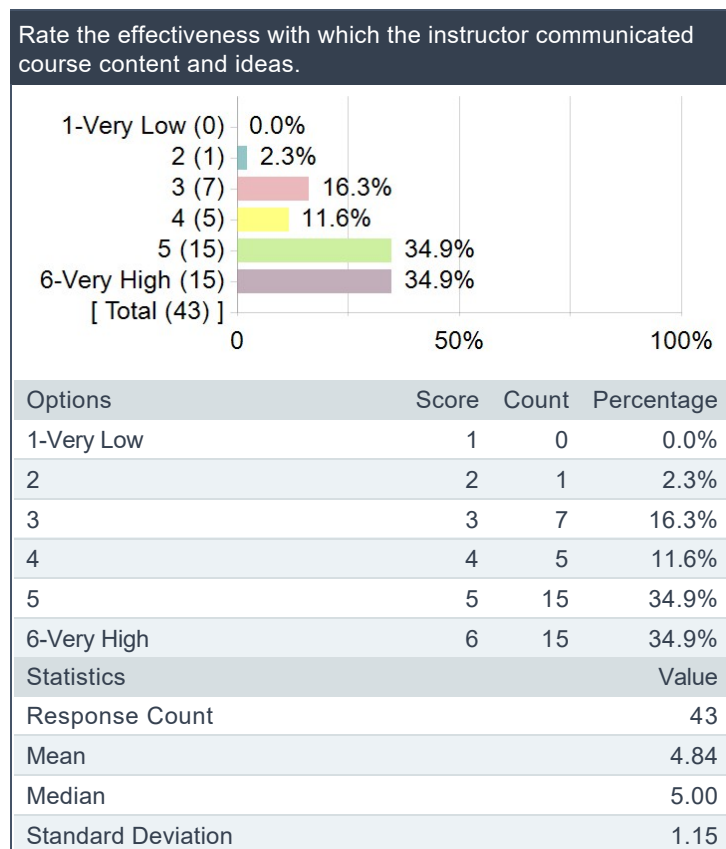
Options	Score	Count	Percentage
1-Very Low	1	1	2.4%
2	2	5	11.9%
3	3	10	23.8%
4	4	9	21.4%
5	5	6	14.3%
6-Very High	6	11	26.2%
Statistics			Value
Response Count			42
Mean			4.12
Median			4.00
Standard Deviation			1.47

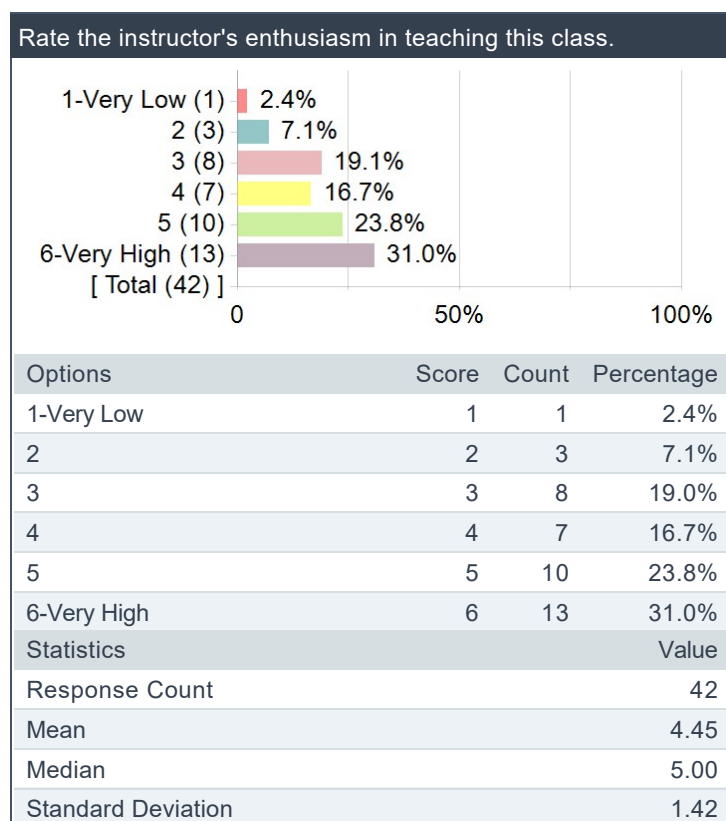
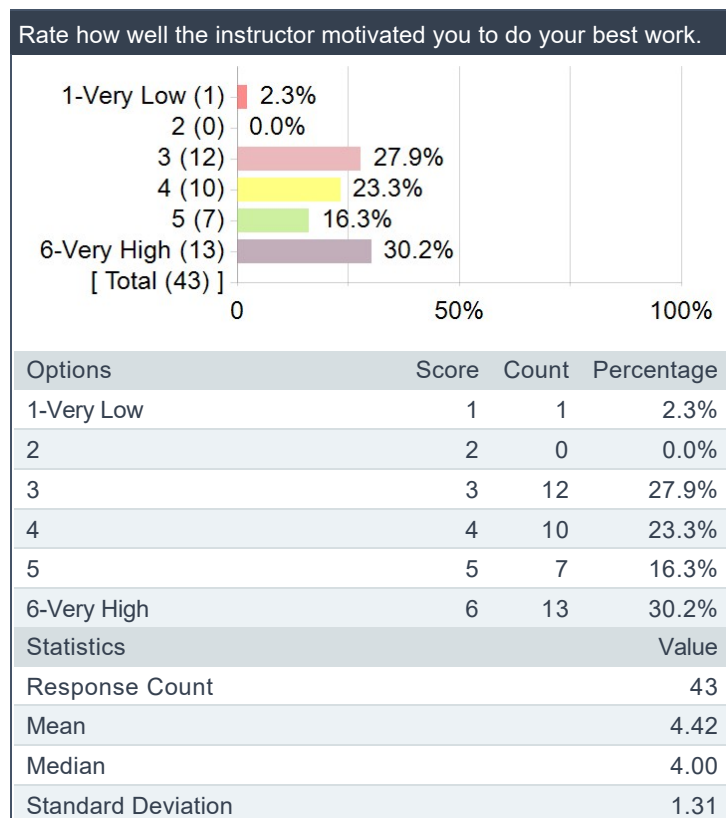
Rate how well the instructor identified the important concepts in the course.

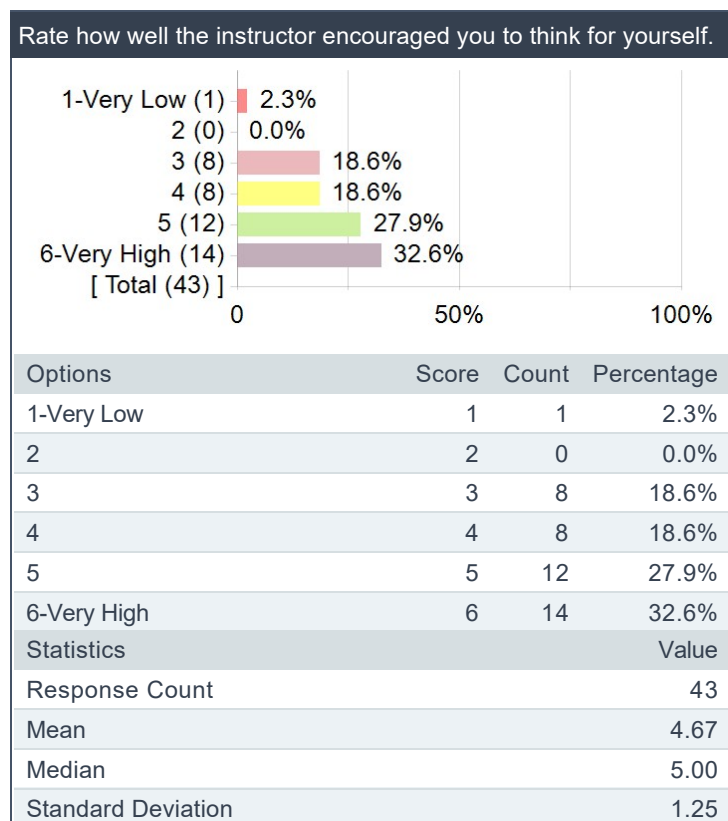
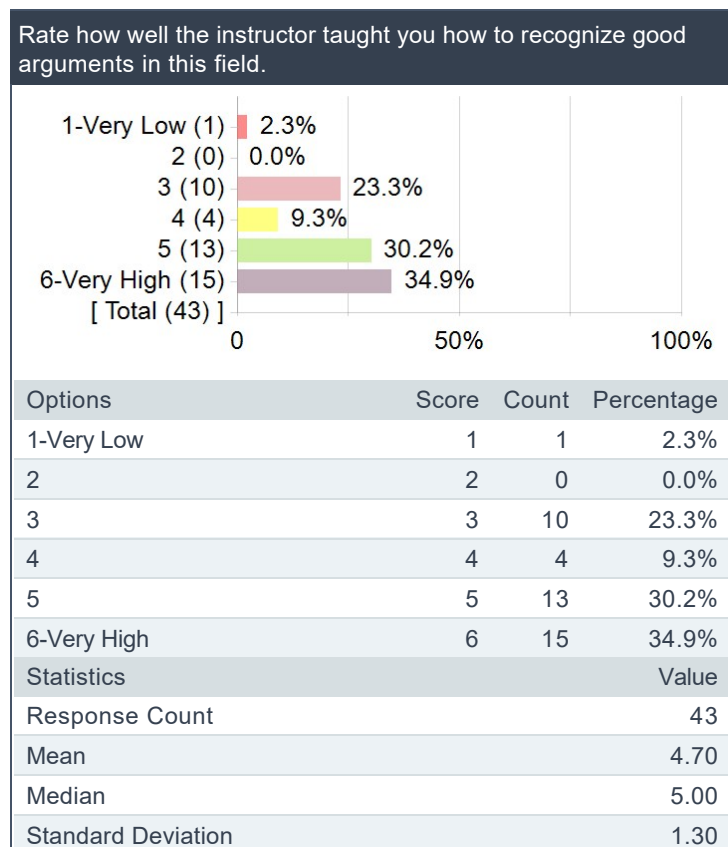
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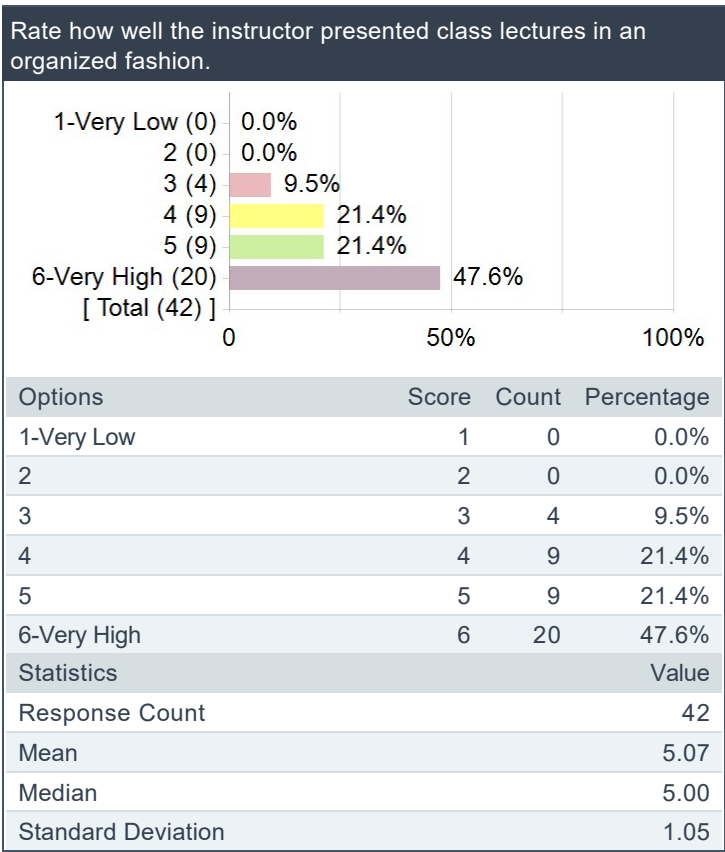
Options	Score	Count	Percentage
1-Very Low	1	0	0.0%
2	2	3	7.0%
3	3	3	7.0%
4	4	7	16.3%
5	5	15	34.9%
6-Very High	6	15	34.9%
Statistics			Value
Response Count			43
Mean			4.84
Median			5.00
Standard Deviation			1.19

Rate how well prepared the instructor was for the class.**Rate the effectiveness with which the instructor communicated course content and ideas.**

Rate the instructor's enthusiasm in teaching this class.**Rate how well the instructor motivated you to do your best work.**

Rate how well the instructor encouraged you to think for yourself.**Rate how well the instructor taught you how to recognize good arguments in this field.**

Rate how well the instructor presented class lectures in an organized fashion.



OPEN-ENDED QUESTIONS

Did the course help you learn? Why or why not?

Comments
A little bit, but mostly not very well and disconnected.
Yes, I liked the format
This course was not very engaging. Lectures were boring.
yeah bc good materials
The course did help me learn because the weekly assignments allowed me to strengthen my understanding of concepts in different ways that all came together to support each other.
Yes but requires students to put in the work to get learning out of it. Very much a student-dependent course with what u learn
N/A
I did definitely learn about some topics that I didn't know about before, but I didn't feel intellectually challenged at all, and by the half way mark I sort of felt like I was just coasting through. Selfishly, I liked the fact that this was an easy A and required minimal effort, but I do think this class should be restructured and made to be harder. There could be exams and projects. Maybe an intro to some coding languages.
Yes, very enriching experience.
I think the optional attendance policy made it very compelling to not come to class, which, in my opinion, would be detrimental to one's ability to learn the material in this class. I almost always went to class, so I was able to get a good amount out of it. If you took AP Stats, a lot of it was familiar.
I learned enough to understand the basics of the course. It helped me learn for the topics I put effort into learning.
This course was a waste of my time. Yes, it was easy and I got the A at the end of the day, but the instruction was painfully boring, pointless, and lacking of direction. The professor was not engaged, looked like he desperately never wanted to be at lecture, and I didn't end up learning anything. The only thing I learned from the research design critiques were what the studies were about; not how to read critically, not how to analyze experiments, and certainly not how to apply what we were learning in class. The AI Memo consisted of general AI slop, and while I understand wanting to engage more with AI because it's a part of our society now, I think we can agree we're tired of it and the nonsense it produces, and the fact I had to engage with it for this class just made me more lazy with my effort, and annoyed I had to use it. I did not learn a thing, to say the least.
Learning was dependent on yourself so there was no standard metric to weigh your efforts against, so long as you were satisfied with the grade you'd receive.
I learned a decent amount about research methods
Yes; I became more knowledgeable in AI use and how to really read and understand research papers.
There are three weekly assignments and discussion sections and all are very achievable. Class attendance isn't required, and it's based on a point system. The class truly is what you make of it whether you need it to be more chill and just complete the weekly assignments or you have the time to dive into the material.
Kind of. Interesting set of assignments we had to complete, and material was relevant regarding empirical methods in political science used in today's political scene.
Yes. The research critiques forced me to look at and learn about the specific methods used to conduct political research.
yes
i think it was comprehensive, and the weekly quizzes and reading critiques helped a lot.
Yes! The textbook readings were super helpful and technical but understandable.
Yes, it helped me learn.
Yep, applying all the content and ideas from lectures and the textbook to actual political science research and spending most of discussion sections talking about those relationships helped foster a more concrete understanding of the material.
The course helped me learn in that it had the materials there for me to learn although it was up to me how much i wanted to use them
The optionality of class attendance was the biggest impact for my learning in this course, I think. I started the quarter by going to classes, but by week 5, around when we had fully lost our incentive of extra points at the end of the quarter, it felt somewhat redundant to attend lecture. Without a sense of class community, it was very demotivating to attend. I also think that lectures were paced too slowly to the point where I would lose focus regardless if I was at lecture.
This class helped me read more critically when analyzing reports.
Helped me learn at research methods

Please summarize your reaction to this course focusing on the aspects that were most important to you.

Comments
Very straightforward class. Contract grading with very doable assignments. Discussion is essentially mandatory but it was honestly helpful to go anyways to complete the homework later. This class is a requirement for poli sci but don't worry about it taking up unnecessary space in your schedule and you will still learn useful things when you put in the effort
Did not learn that much, but the professor was nice.
Prof. Diaz is super chill. I really liked the format of the "point system" where you have weekly assignments and you must complete a specific amount to receive an A. Busy work class, but 100% better than midterms and finals.
This course was not very engaging. Lectures were boring.
take it good class very nice
The course was fine, but it mostly consisted of busy work, and the lectures were not very engaging.
Good course if you have a very busy schedule. Classes don't require participation, no midterm/final, and simply weekly assignments. If students do engage with course learning, there is a lot of learning to be done, but ultimately it comes down to how you approach the class.
Do the work and the benefits will pay off
This class is a guaranteed A. You can go to lecture and read the textbook if you want to learn a little bit about the field, but as someone who only missed three lectures, I still feel like I didn't learn that much about the empirical area of political science. I wish we had done some stuff that was actually useful as someone who is very interested in data science.
I had to take this course as a major requirement. I learned NOTHING – you could if you would like, but its easy to just go through the motions with this class. Easy A. Go to class once in a while, but not all the time
Yes, very enriching experience.
Not a difficult course — the weekly assignments are a bit tedious, but if you do them, you are basically guaranteed to get an A. To learn, I would recommend going to class. Most people don't.
Pretty easy class. No exams, just assignments. Grade is based on how much work you complete, not as much the content. No coding or anything too math based, some basic stats. There are canvas quizzes but you get infinite attempts.
This was a solid course! You definitely get what you put into it and you need to be on top of it from the beginning.
What I stated above.
Class was fine, though attendance was not mandatory so participation suffered because of it. All assignments are under contract grading so it was pretty forgiving but be aware how many weeks of assignments are left so as to not fall behind and hurt your grade. Lectures could stand to be more interesting vocally and visually, but the context beyond the basics at the beginning of the quarter were interesting.
This class is a really easy way to fulfill a political science major requirement or the EDR distrobution requirement. You'll get out what you put into it, but it's a very easy A. Entirely based on completion and the work took me a maximum of 3 hours per week.
I did learn a lot from this course. It is a bit hard to stay engaged in the material sometimes, but what you get out of this course depends on whether you're willing to make it relevant to your interests and whether you're willing to go to class. You're paying a bunch of money to be here. Go to lecture.
Take this course with Professor Diaz! The grades are cumulative so you complete a few assignments each week to earn points that are converted to the final grade. There are no exams and the readings are very helpful
Not too intellectually rigorous. Material was relevant regarding empirical methods used to understand today's political scene.
You can do this course completely from home/online. That was super great, and often I could skip a research critique if I had a busy week ahead of me because the points system allows you to miss a total of 4 assignments and/or discussions and still have an A. Incredible class.
interesting, good distro, work took up time but wasn't graded too harshly
loved this course, attendance wasn't taken though the prof said if the overall attendance is over 50% he would give 40 extra credits to everyone (I don't think we did that). But grading was broken down into points e.g. 10 points for weekly quizzes, reading critiques, AI memo, and section participation. The grading isn't harsh so as long as you do the work its okay.
HIGHLY RECOMMEND THIS CLASS! For one, if you put the work in you can easily get an A. For another thing, if you ever want to do poli sci research (you probably will) then DO The textbook readings!! I took this class to also prepare for my Summer research and it's really helpful! Attendance is not required either so if you do the readings and the AI memos and research critiques (super doable each week) then you are good to go. TAKE THIS!
This course is pretty easy. There is a point system and as long as you reach a certain threshold of points by the end of the quarter you get an A. I don't feel like I learned a lot in this course but this is great for filling the empirical methods requirement.
Easy class for poli sci.

Comments
Contract grading: four weekly grades (Research design critique, AI Memo, Quiz, and Discussion participation), each worth 10 points. You essentially decide yourr grade by deciding how many assignments to complete
Great class ! Proffesor Diaz was great. Repetitive work but enjoyed doing it and learned a lot from the readings !
The course uses contract grading which is great, and it's not particularly difficult content either. Basically as long as you just do the weekly assignments (which only take a few hours per week) you'll get an A. Attending lectures also isn't required, but it can be helpful for understanding the content since Professor Diaz is pretty good at explaining the material and highlighting what's actually important. There are no midterms or final, just weekly assignments and discussion section participation so it's very low–stress as long as you're willing to put in a couple hours each week.
This course is set up to be take as much as you want from it and the professor recognizes that. You can treat this course however you'd like from a serious time commitment to a light 4th class
Easy A, but honestly regret taking this as my poli sci methodology course because I don't feel like I learned anything. Lecture attendance was optional, no exams, just weekly reading, 2 written assignments (one which asks you to use AI???), weekly open note online quiz, and discussion participation. Grateful for the A, but kind of wish I did a different methodology course so I could have actually learned about empirical methods in political science :/
This was such a strange class. The professor said on day 1 that it wasn't necessary to come to class to get an A... and then no one showed up. I was one of about 10 kids, out of 62 in the class, in most of the lectures, and I questioned going most of the time. The content was fine, and it wasn't difficult at all. I was just really confused about why I decided to be there most of the time.
Great course that didnt require a lot of time
Professor Diaz is great! He is very understanding of the student experience as reflected in the structure of the course. Seeing that Professor Diaz uses a contract grading system, you can easily do well in this course, but how much you actually learn is up to you — you get out what you put in. This is the ideal course for when you have a busy quarter and need a bit of leeway in your schedule.

What are the primary teaching strengths of the instructor?

Comments
He was nice.
Smart and engaging
Knowledgable about the subject matter.
everything
The lectures were very organized and made concepts easier to understand than if you tried learning them on your own.
Super interested in class, engaging lecturer
N/A
The slideshows and quizzes were helpful in identifying important topics.
Relevant and fun professor
Very organized, clearly knows a lot about the subject.
His lectures do a good job of grabbing attention
Diaz was organized in his canvas layout, lecture slides, and instructions for homework and assignments were clear.
Great organization
Professor Diaz is incredibly organized and is always willing to answer questions and offer his support.
Clear with course expectations
Very conversational teaching style, which takes the tension off the class.
good lecture
organized funny
Super understanding class structure and helpful readings!
very passionate about the topics
Good.
Entertaining and encourages participation
Very well organized and prepared for class, helpful lecture slides.
Ability to communicate with students
He was very prepared for each class.
NA
Professor Diaz is great! The structure of the course was very accommodating of my busy schedule, and empowered me to take responsibility for both my own performance and learning.

What are the primary weaknesses, if any, of the instruction?

Comments
He made us use AI.
N/A
Monotone, dry jokes and overall not super enthusiastic about the course
nothing
The lectures were not very engaging.
Not any that I can think of but usually lecture numbers drop naturally because attendance isn't required
N/A
Lecture felt very monotone and boring sometimes.
Nothing
Not super enthusiastic and a little monotonous in lecturing.
I wish some of the assignments were due earlier in the quarter to balance it out.
While the slides of the lecture were organized, Diaz never looked like he wanted to be at lecture, was always annoyed when certain people spoke out in class which meant only the same two people ever participated, and did care whatsoever that people attended his lecture. He was passive aggressive, rude, and very boring in lecture, and I can confidently say I felt de-motivated to put any work into this class because of his lack of energy, passion, and care.
Not the most engaging but tried to get students to answer questions in class and engage the class in that way (mostly just an issue of student engagement and not of the professor)
Lectures could move a bit slowly sometimes.
n/a
None.
none
n/a
N/A
The class felt like it moved a bit slow sometimes, but I think that's probably just because I already had some background with the course subject.
Lectures were paced too slowly, lacked engagement
It felt strange that he said no one technically had to show up on day one because sitting in the class with only 8 other people felt incredibly strange.
NA

Can you offer suggestions for improvement?

Comments
Don't use AI.
N/A
Encourage students to come to office hours
n/a
It might help to offer opportunities for hands-on learning during class to get students more engaged.
No
N/A
More projects and required attendance, maybe a no tech policy.
Nothing
Make attendance required.
I wish attendance could be a point section you could earn, it seems more fair to those who attend class.
The AI Memos felt like a waste of time, I would much rather just have to do a page summary of the textbook reading instead.
No
I wish more students attended class.
n/a
None.
no
Maybe discuss the textbook a bit during section?
n/a
N/A
Not really.
Require attendance or have exams to encourage attendance. While it is very generous of you to purposefully not give exams so that students can focus on other courses, it immediately demotivated probably 40 of my peers from attending lecture. This course has high potential if you can keep students in class so there is some sense of community.
n/a
NA
Honestly, I think Professor Diaz should mandate lecture attendance. He is incredibly gracious for not penalizing students who miss lecture, but this can easily be abused and I hate to see his time and efforts go to waste.